

How to Use the GALE Virtual Library Topic Finder

A student guide to finding better research sources.

Overview

The **GALE Virtual Library** contains thousands of books, reference works, and scholarly resources. While a basic keyword search can quickly locate information, it often returns far more results than are useful.

The **Topic Finder** helps researchers narrow broad topics into more focused concepts by identifying relationships between commonly occurring subjects. This allows you to discover more relevant sources and refine your research more efficiently.

This guide will walk you through using the Topic Finder and several additional search tools built into GALE Virtual Library.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this guide, you will be able to:

- ☐ Perform a basic search in GALE Virtual Library.
 - ☐ Use the Topic Finder to refine a research topic.
 - ☐ Narrow a broad topic into a more specific research question.
 - ☐ Evaluate search results.
 - ☐ Use filters to locate more relevant sources.
 - ☐ Search within existing results.
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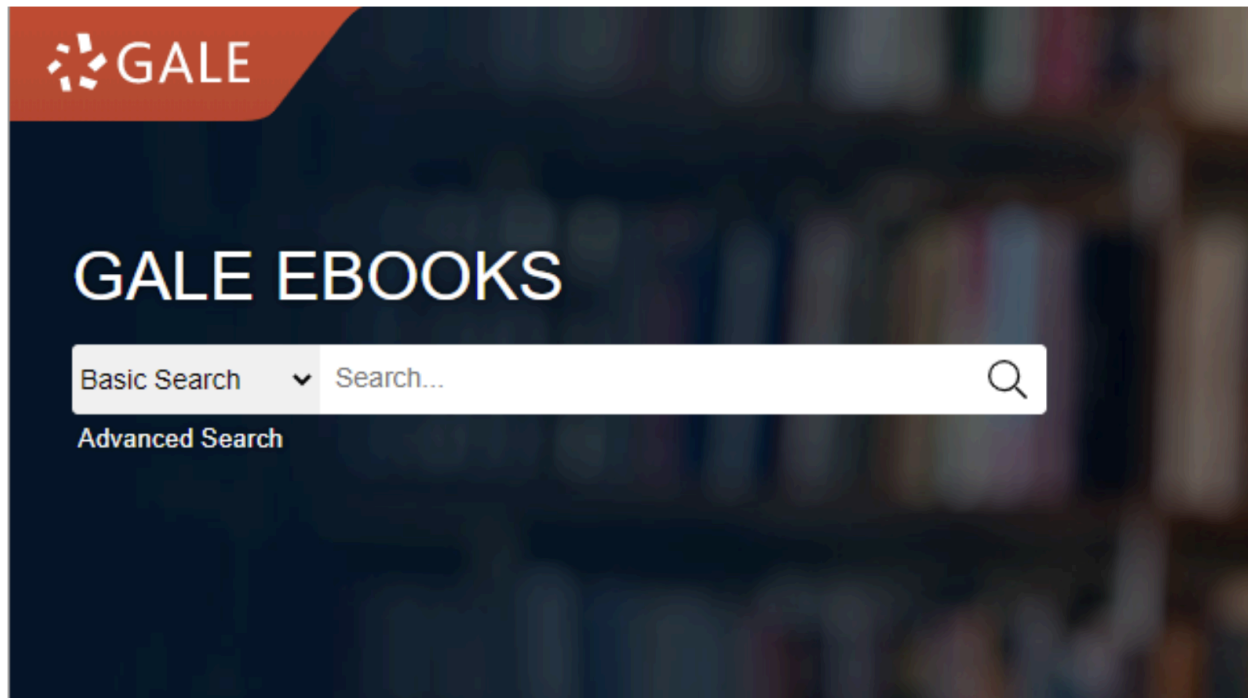
Before you begin:

Select a topic to research. Write your topic on the lines below

Step 1 - Open GALE Virtual Library

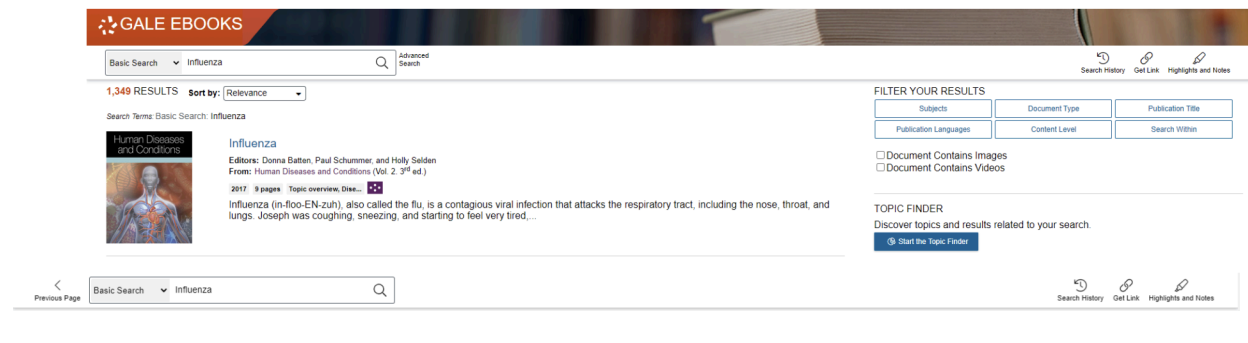
Navigate to the Hoover Library website and open the **GALE Virtual Library** database.

Once the database loads, you should see the GALE home page with the search box.



Step 2 - Perform a Basic Search

Enter your research topic exactly as you normally would in Google. At this stage, your search should remain fairly broad. The following example is for "Influenza."



Step 3 - Open Topic Finder

After your search results appear:

1. Locate **Topic Finder** on the right side of the page.
2. Select **Start Topic Finder**.

GALE EBOOKS

Basic Search Influenza Advanced Search

1,349 RESULTS Sort by: Relevance

Search Terms: Basic Search: Influenza

Influenza
Editors: Donna Batten, Paul Schummer, and Holly Selden
From: Human Diseases and Conditions (Vol. 2, 3rd ed.)
2017 9 pages Topic overview, Dis...
Influenza (in-floo-EN-zuh) also called the flu, is a contagious viral infection that attacks the respiratory tract, including the nose, throat, and lungs. Joseph was coughing, sneezing, and starting to feel very tired,...

TOPIC FINDER
Discover topics and results related to your search.
[Start the Topic Finder](#)

Topic Finder automatically analyzes your search results and identifies related concepts that frequently appear together. The larger a tile appears, the more frequently it occurs with your search term.

Tiles closer to **red** generally represent stronger relationships.

Search...

Search Terms: Basic Search: Influenza

There are two ways to visualize below which words and subjects are found most often in the text of your search results.

Visualization: ☒ Tiles ☐ Wheel

RESULTS
Clicking on a topic wheel or tile narrows your original search results to the documents also containing that subject or term.
Click on a section to display results.

HOW IT WORKS
This tool takes the titles, subjects, and approximately the first 100 words from a subset of your top results and feeds them into an algorithm. Keywords shown in the graphics are those found most often in the text with your search term.
The topic for "Illinois" might bring up expected connections from the text like "Chicago," along with unexpected but commonly related terms like "water," "steel," and the names of people who appear frequently in documents about Illinois.

Checkpoint Activity 1

Question 1

Which terms appear in **red/orange**?

Question 2

Which terms appear in **green/yellow**?

Understanding Topic Finder

Topic Finder is designed to help researchers move from broad topics toward increasingly specific concepts. Instead of reading through hundreds or thousands of unrelated sources, you can explore related topics visually and quickly narrow your search. This allows you to spend more time reading useful information and less time sorting through unrelated results.

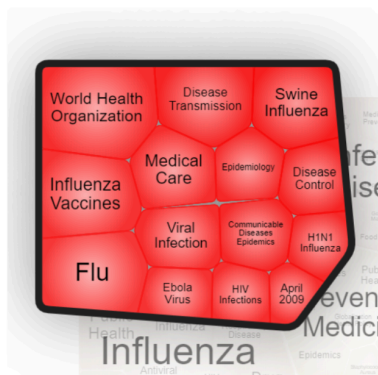
For example:

The original search for **Influenza** produced well over one thousand results.

Using the **Topic Finder**, we can reduce those results to 36 closely related articles.

There are two ways to visualize below which words and subjects are found most often in the text of your search results.

Visualization: ☒ Tiles ☐ Wheel



RESULTS

Clicking on a topic wheel or tile narrows your original search results to the documents also containing that subject or term.

RESULTS FOR TOPIC: **HEALTH** (36)

Pandemic

A pandemic is an epidemic of an that has spread across large portions of several continents or even worldwide The English word comes from two Greek words that mean all and people A noncontagious disease or...

[AIDS (Disease)] [Bacterial infections] [Black Death, ca. 1347-1400] [Cholera] [Communicable diseases] [Epidemics] [Famines] [HIV infections] [Influenza] [Jenner, Edward] [Plague] [Smallpox] [Typhus] [Vaccination] [Water pollution] [World Health Organization]

Carrier of SARS Made Seven Flights Before Treatment

Globalization and Health Newspaper article By Keith Bradsher Date April 10 2003 Source Keith Bradsher Carrier of SARS Made Seven Flights Before Treatment New York Times April 10 2003 5507 130451 About the...

[Air travel] [Bradsher, Keith] [Disease transmission] [Severe acute respiratory syndrome] [World Health] [World Health Organization]

Alcohol Use and Abuse

Alcohol is the most widely used addictive substance in the world Addiction primarily a brain disorder caused by compulsive substances seeking without regard for consequences is accompanied by chemical changes in the...

[Addiction] [Alcoholic beverage industry] [Alcoholic beverages] [Alcoholism] [Alcoholism treatment] [Drinking (Alcoholic beverages)] [Fetal alcohol syndrome] [Liquor laws] [Public Health] [Wine making] [World Health Organization]

Dengue

Dengue is a mosquito-borne viral infection afflicting tropical and subtropical regions of the world Symptoms of the disease include high fever severe headache joint and muscle pain and rash among other flu like...

[Dengue fever] [Dengue virus] [Disease transmission] [Epidemics] [Epidemiology] [Mosquitoes] [Public Health] [Vector control] [Virus diseases] [World Health Organization] [Yellow fever mosquito]

There are two ways to visualize below which words and subjects are found most often in the text of your search results.

Visualization: ☒ Tiles ☐ Wheel

Clicking on a topic wheel or tile narrows your original search results to the documents also containing that subject or term.

RESULTS FOR TOPIC: SWINE INFLUENZA (6)

H1N1 Influenza A (2009)

2009 H1N1 influenza initially termed a swine flu is an infectious respiratory disease caused by a subtype of the influenza A virus first identified in April 2009 It is also denoted as the AH1N1 Virus The virus and...

[Epidemics] [Public health] [Swine Influenza]

H1N1 Influenza A

2009 H1N1 initially termed a swine flu is an infectious respiratory disease caused by a subtype of the influenza A virus first identified in April 2009 It is also denoted as the AH1N1 virus The virus and...

[Communicable diseases] [Epidemics] [Influenza vaccines] [Influenza viruses] [Public health] [Swine Influenza]

Epidemiology

Epidemiology is the study of the origin and cause of disease among populations Epidemiology is an increasingly important part of public health because rapidly increasing human populations provide a fertile breeding...

[AIDS (Disease)] [Cancer] [Cholera] [Communicable diseases] [Epidemics] [Epidemiologists] [Epidemiology] [Public health] [Snow, John (English physician)] [Swine Influenza]

Conflict, Violence, and Terrorism: Health Impacts

The direct effects of war terrorism conflict and general violence on collective human health are readily apparent Military combatants and personnel are subject to casualties and civilians persons in proximity to...

[Birth defects] [Epidemics] [Food supply] [Foodborne diseases] [Medical care] [Plague of Athens, ca. 430-426 BC] [Post-traumatic stress disorder] [Public health] [Refugees] [Sanitation] [Swine Influenza] [Terrorism] [United Nations. Office of United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees] [Violence] [War casualties] [Wars] [World Trade Center and Pentagon Attacks, 2001]

Question 3

Step 4 - Explore Related Topics

Select several different topics from the Topic Finder visualization.

Notice how the list of results changes as you choose different concepts.

Broad topics generally produce larger collections of sources.

Specific topics usually return fewer, but more relevant, results.

Step 5 - Filter by Document Type

Return to your search results.

Locate the **Document Type** filter.

Experiment with several different document types. Examples include:

- Academic Journals
- News Articles
- Reference Articles
- Magazines
- Biographies

Filtering by document type can help you locate sources that best fit your assignment.

Activity 3

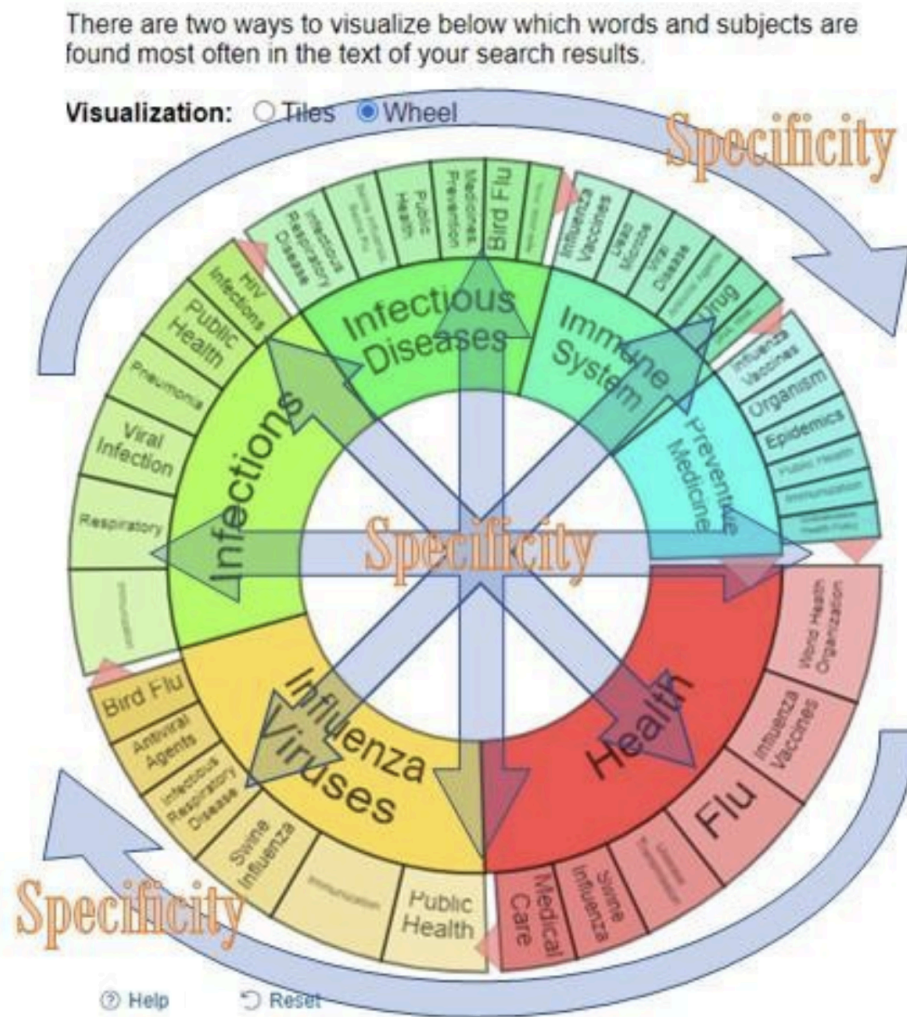
Question 5

Which document type produced the largest number of results?

Optional Feature - Wheel View

Topic Finder offers two different visualizations, Tile View and Wheel View, but they display the same information.

The **Wheel** view organizes related concepts in a circular hierarchy, allowing you to move from broad ideas toward increasingly specific topics.



Try switching between both views and see which version you prefer.

Reflection

Which Topic Finder feature did you find most helpful?

How did your research topic become more focused during this activity?

Final Checklist

Before moving on, confirm that you have completed each task.

- ☐ Performed a basic search.
- ☐ Opened Topic Finder.
- ☐ Explored related topics.
- ☐ Narrowed your search.
- ☐ Filtered by document type.
- ☐ Compared Tile and Wheel views.
- ☐ Reflected on your research process.

Congratulations! You have successfully used the GALE Virtual Library Topic Finder to refine a research topic and locate more focused sources.